

Krishnaa Vadivel | Research Engineer | Scientific Computing | Machine Learning | Electrical Engineering

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Profile

Broad-profile electrical engineering PhD researcher with training and project work spanning computational physics, semiconductor physics, integrated photonics, scientific machine learning, embedded systems, digital design, and high-performance scientific software. The core strength is connecting mathematical models, physical intuition, and implementation detail across research and engineering settings.

Research Experience

Yale University, Electrical Engineering

Research Assistant / PhD Researcher

2021–present

- Developed graph neural networks and automatic-differentiation models in Python to predict material properties including optical emission spectra.
- Developed first-principles and many-body simulation software in Python and C++ using MPI, OpenMP, PETSc, SLEPc, CUDA, ROCm, and CMake for large simulation and linear-algebra workloads.
- Built distributed and accelerator-enabled applications for Frontier, Perlmutter, Frontera, and related clusters, spanning both NVIDIA and AMD GPU systems.
- Worked on light-matter interaction and quantum many-body modeling, including self-trapped-exciton and exciton-polaron problems relevant to semiconductor and photonic materials.
- Developed early-PhD cleanroom and characterization experience through GaN power-device fabrication, MOCVD, selective-area etching, SEM, cathodoluminescence, and Raman analysis.
- Built agentic automation with LangChain, OpenAI API models, and local Ollama models to read documentation and papers, then generate structured inputs for first-principles software.
- Support embedded-systems instruction and hardware-oriented lab work through teaching-assistant responsibilities tied to firmware, debugging, and instrumentation.
- Co-authored a 2025 *Journal of the American Chemical Society* paper on ultrafast self-trapped exciton formation in lead-free double halide perovskites and presented related APS talks in 2024, 2025, and 2026.

Professional Experience

Probe Technologies Inc. / Weatherford Wireline Services

Software and Embedded Systems Engineer

2019–2021

- Built parallel applications with CUDA and OpenCL fallback for large acoustic waveform and sensor datasets used in engineering diagnostics and field-tool analysis.
- Developed embedded software and digital logic for sensing, logging, and control functions using Lattice FPGA, PIC32, dsPIC, STM32, and C8051-based systems.
- Supported board- and system-level engineering tasks including oscilloscope-based debugging, integration testing, field validation, and selective PCB modifications in Altium.
- Developed full-stack server applications with ASP.NET and Microsoft SQL Server for real-time control of company tool testing, data collection, and data processing.
- Developed C# GUI applications for preparing customer inputs and interacting with deployed hardware systems.
- Used dolfinx-based finite-element analysis for frequency analysis of steel pipes in wells.

FindLight

Photonics Technical Writer

2018–2019

- Produced technical articles and engineering-facing content covering lasers, optics, photonics components, and optoelectronic systems.

Selected Projects

Machine Learning Models for Material Properties

- Developed PyTorch Geometric graph neural networks and automatic-differentiation models for molecular-property prediction and optical-properties calculations in material systems.

Semiconductor Device Simulation

- Built numerical treatments of electrostatics and transport equations, including Poisson, drift-diffusion, and pn-junction-style models linking semiconductor theory with simulation practice.

Integrated Photonics Bandpass Filter

- Developed Meep FDTD simulations for a ring-resonator-based integrated-photonics bandpass filter that was later fabricated and tested with an erbium-doped fiber laser.

Container Orchestration for First-Principles Computing

- Developed CUDA-ready and cross-environment containers for first-principles software stacks and published them to Docker Hub for portable scientific computing.

FPGA AI Accelerator and Digital Design Work

- Implemented Verilog-based accelerator and processor projects to demonstrate datapath design, verification workflows, and hardware-oriented compute thinking.

Embedded Robotics and Human-Interface Projects

- Built robotics and embedded-system class projects including a surface-EMG robotic hand that was later published in Circuit Cellar, plus maze-navigation work with wireless coordination.

Integrated Photonics and FDTD Modeling

- Simulated band-pass and resonator-style photonic structures with Meep-based FDTD workflows for integrated-optics exploration.

Agentic Scientific Automation

- Built retrieval-driven tooling that reads software documentation and research papers to generate structured inputs and workflow scaffolds for computational science.

Education

Yale University

PhD, Electrical Engineering

2021–present

Ongoing work spanning computational materials, many-body theory, semiconductor-relevant modeling, and scientific software.

Yale University

MPhil, Electrical Engineering

2023

Yale University

MS, Electrical Engineering

2023

Cornell University

MEng, Electrical and Computer Engineering

2017–2018

Included stochastic-computing-related work, device-oriented EE topics, and advanced design coursework.

Cornell University

BS, Electrical and Computer Engineering

2013–2017

Included embedded systems, robotics, controls, and strong math/physics/computing preparation.

Selected Publications

2025: de Paula, A. M., Li, S., Hou, B., Vadivel, S., Teles-Ferreira, D. C., Iudica, A., Kabacinski, P., Hosseini, H., McArthur, J., Cerullo, G., et al. (2025). Time-domain observation of ultrafast self-trapped exciton formation in lead-free double halide perovskites. *Journal of the American Chemical Society*, 147(32), 28923–28931.

Selected Conference Presentations

2026: Vadivel, S., Grande, R. D., Strubbe, D. A., & Qiu, D. Y. (2026). First-principles study of exciton-polarons and self-trapped excitons. *APS Global Physics Summit 2026*.

2025: Vadivel, S., Qiu, D. Y., Grande, R. D., & Strubbe, D. A. (2025). First-principles study of self-trapped exciton formation in double perovskites. *APS Global Physics Summit 2025*.

2024: Vadivel, S., & Qiu, D. (2024). First-principles study of self-trapped exciton formation in double perovskites using excited state forces. *APS March Meeting Abstracts 2024*, F01–007.

Selected Coursework

Mathematics: Differential Geometry; Abstract Algebra; Honors Mathematical Analysis II

Computer Science: Theoretical Computer Science; Probabilistic Machine Learning

Physics: Graduate Quantum Mechanics I–II; Solid State Physics I–II; Many-Body Quantum Physics

Electrical Engineering: Semiconductor Physics; Thin Film Science; Lasers and Optoelectronics; Integrated Photonics; VLSI Design; Analog VLSI Design; Mathematics of Signals and Systems; Advanced Embedded Systems

Technical Skills

Languages: Python, C, C++, CUDA, JavaScript, Bash, PowerShell, C#

Scientific Computing: MPI, OpenMP, PETSc, SLEPc, mpi4py, petsc4py, slepc4py, NumPy, pandas, SciPy, SymPy, matplotlib

Machine Learning: PyTorch, PyTorch Geometric, scikit-learn, graph neural networks, transformers, agentic automation

Hardware: Verilog, Lattice FPGA, PIC32, dsPIC, STM32, C8051, sensor interfaces, PCB bring-up, oscilloscope debugging

Software / Systems: ASP.NET, Microsoft SQL Server, Linux command line, Docker, Docker Compose, Kubernetes, gcloud

HPC Platforms: Frontier, Frontera, Perlmutter, and related national-lab or university HPC environments